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THE MATHEMATICAL ROAD TO THE FUTURE

Towards the end of 1998 I wrote an email to what had become an international band of merry men and women. I was taking off from Melbourne – ‘the planet’s most liveable city’ – to throw myself into the wider world of snow, ice, slush and imploding Communism. I don’t know how other people meet colleagues, but my approach has always been a little, say, existential. You like someone’s face or the fact they loved a book that you read and liked, too. Maybe they set up a group or opposed some fetid old council or just rambled late one night in a nice way. I wasn’t yet the head of an organisation, but, even when I was, my methods have remained the same. Keep moving on, keep trusting people. ‘If anyone feels like getting together for beer, vodka, Siberian bear steak, or just a good yarn, please let me know,’ I wrote in the round-robin email.

28 Oct 98	San Francisco
5 Nov 98	London
6 Nov 98	Frankfurt/Berlin
9 Nov 98	Poland/Slovenia/Eastern Europe
15 Nov 98	Helsinki
16 Nov 98	St Petersburg
20 Nov 98	Moscow
25 Nov 98	Irkutsk
29 Nov 98	Ulan Bator
3 Dec 98	Beijing

The itinerary was ambitious, but it worked out. As I met, stayed with, drank and ate with like-minded young people across Europe and Asia, I felt at every turn I was seeing a new world. It was a world running at its own